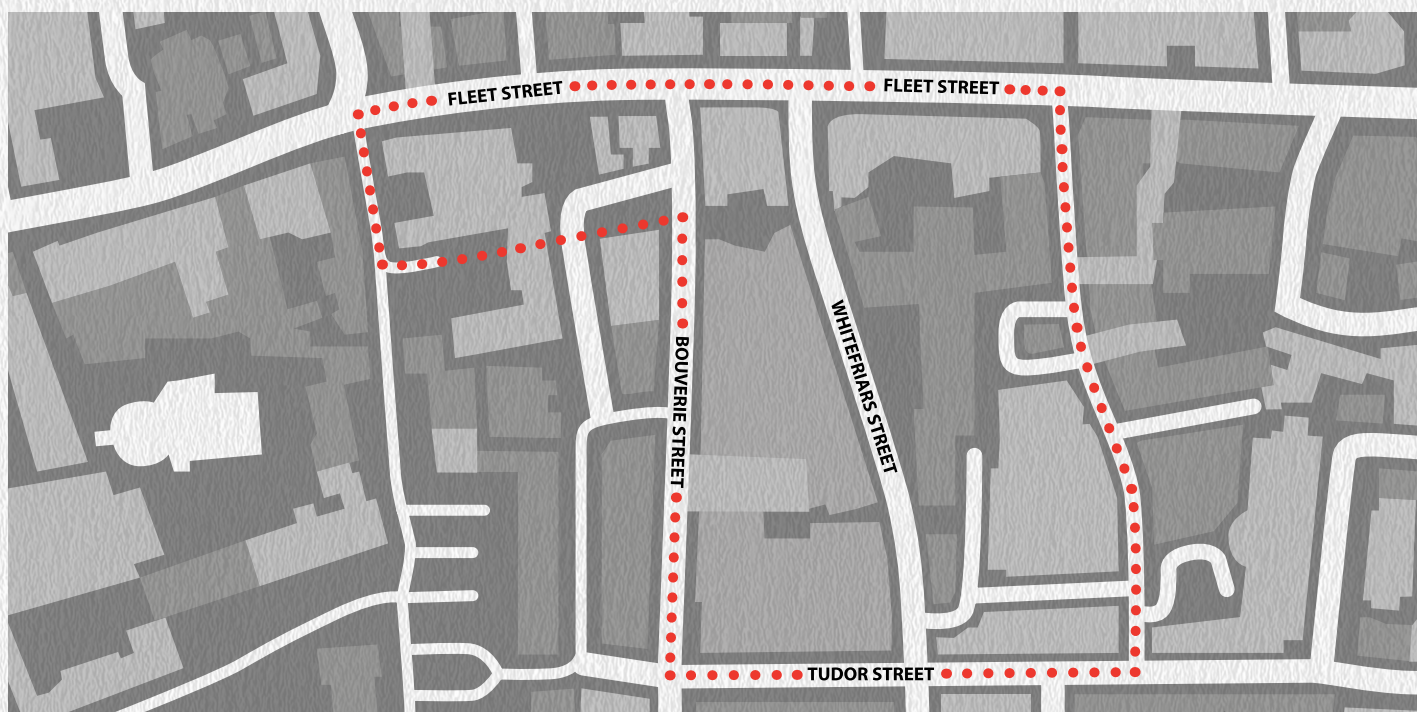


Alsatia

No. 142

THE HERITAGE of FLEET STREET

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The map shows the approximate boundaries of Alsatia against the current street layout; Alsatia extended to the banks of the Thames, which at that time were inland of the present line of the Embankment. Alsatia had outliers (not shown here) at the Savoy, at Fullers Rents (now Fulwood Place), and at Baldwin's Rents (now Baldwin's Gardens).

From the 1670s to 1697, the area of London between Fleet Street and the Thames was colloquially known as Alsatia.

It comprised the Precinct of Whitefriars, formerly a Carmelite monastery, Salisbury Court, Ram Alley and Mitre Court; with outlying areas to the west (the Savoy, property of the Duchy of Lancaster), Fuller's Rents and Baldwin's Gardens.

Across the river were its counterparts in Southwark, sometimes known as Alsatia the Lower: The Mint, The Clink and Montague Close.

Named by the journalist Henry Care after the French region of Alsace, studded by independent cities frequently at war with each other, Alsatia was a liberty claiming legal freedoms for debtors escaping imprisonment.

Since 1352, those who owed money to private individuals could be arrested and imprisoned by their creditors. Throughout the eighteenth and nineteenth centuries, hundreds of thousands were jailed and released only by paying their debts or through relief acts passed by the government. The largest debtor prisons were in London and Southwark: The Fleet, the King's Bench and the Marshalsea. Until the late eighteenth century, gaols were dangerously ramshackle and unhygienic; imprisoned debtors had to pay for their own food and drink.

Observing the principle of the sanctity of life, the Church allowed debtors to seek sanctuary in its properties, and despite Henry VIII's Reformation, these rights persisted in formerly cleric-owned areas such as Whitefriars.

Other secular liberties claimed similar exemptions. After the Interregnum, the Restoration saw imprisonment for debt expand, reviving the sanctuaries.

In the sixteenth and seventeenth centuries, these liberties allowed theatres to operate in these areas; the theatrical connection continued with numerous mentions of Alsatia in the plays of the period. Thomas Shadwell set his 1688 comedy *The Squire of Alsatia* in the sanctuary, depicting the inhabitants as rogues, dandies and impostors.

In 1691, the Alsatians rioted against their neighbours, the lawyers of the Temple, who were blocking one of the passages into Whitefriars. The High Sheriffs of London and their men were called and roundly beaten; one was shot and later died. The King's Guard restored peace; the Cornishman Captain Francis Winter, a veteran of the Dutch Wars, was charged with murder.

After two years of appeals, Winter was hanged on Fleet Street, outside Whitefriars Gate, to instil fear into the Alsatians. It was reported that the inhabitants attended the execution in their thousands; afterwards they took down his body to ensure him a decent burial.

Such a "Rebellious and Unlawful Assembly" and the army's involvement drew attention, and the government declared these were merely "pretended privileged places". Alsatia was abolished by the 1697 "Escape from Prisons" Act, along with the other sanctuaries. Southwark Mint revived until 1722, when an amnesty wrote off the debts of thousands. A brief attempt to establish a sanctuary in Wapping in 1723 was quickly crushed.